DORON

An abstract game for two players

2 players | Ages 8 and up | About 15 minutes | 6 × 6 board

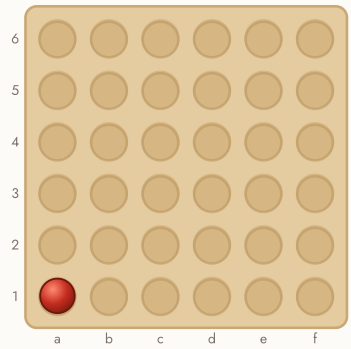
Each turn you move the red doron and drop one of your stones on the square it leaves. **You never choose where your own stone falls: your opponent does.** In return, you decide where your opponent's next stone will fall.

Components

- 1 board of 6 × 6 squares. The corner square **a1**, on Light's left, is the doron's home.
- 18 light stones and 18 dark stones (22 of each for the capture option).
- 1 doron: a red piece, the same shape as the stones. Its name is the Greek word *dōron*, "gift": wherever you leave it, your opponent's next stone will fall.

Aim of the game

Build the **largest group**. A group is a set of stones of one colour linked along their sides. Stones that only touch at a corner are not linked.



1 Start: the doron on its home, a1.

Set-up

The board is empty and the doron stands on its home. Choose colours: **Light plays first.**

Your turn

1. **Move the doron** in a straight line (sideways, forwards, backwards or diagonally) over as many empty squares as you like. It never jumps over a stone and never stops on one.
2. **Place one of your stones on the square it has just left.**

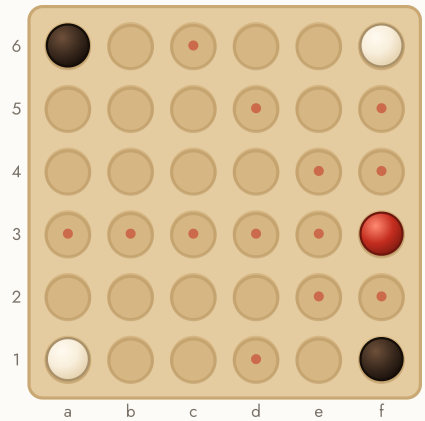
Light's first stone therefore always lands on a1. After that, your stone always lands where your opponent left the doron.

THE KEY IDEA

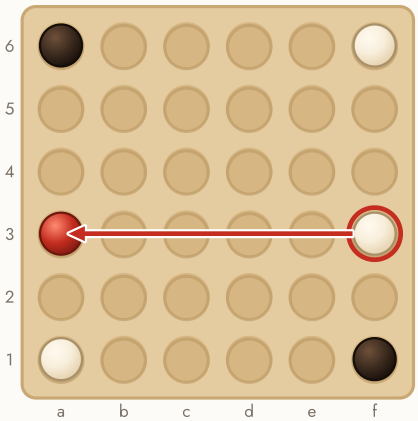
Where you **stop** the doron, your opponent's next stone will fall.

Where your opponent **sends** it, your next stone will fall.

Every move is a double choice: the gift you make, and the gifts you leave open.



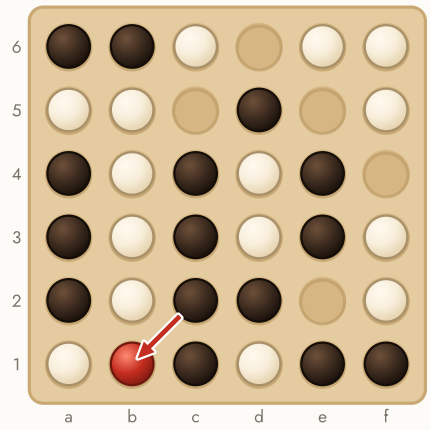
2 **Light to move.** The red dots show every square the doron can reach from f3. The stones on f6 and f1 block the column.



3 Light sends it to **a3** and places a light stone on **f3** (circled). Whatever Dark does next, Dark's stone will land on a3.

End of the game

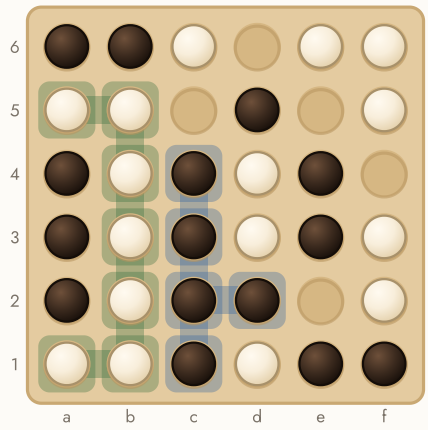
If, at the start of your turn, the doron **cannot move** (all the squares around it are taken), take it off and put one of your stones in its place. The game ends at once. Some squares may stay empty (see figure 4).



4 Dark has just moved the doron from c2 to **b1**. Light cannot move it: Light places a stone on b1 and the game ends.

Who wins?

Each player counts their largest group. **The larger group wins.** If they are the same size, compare the second-largest groups, then the third, and so on. If everything is equal, the game is a draw.



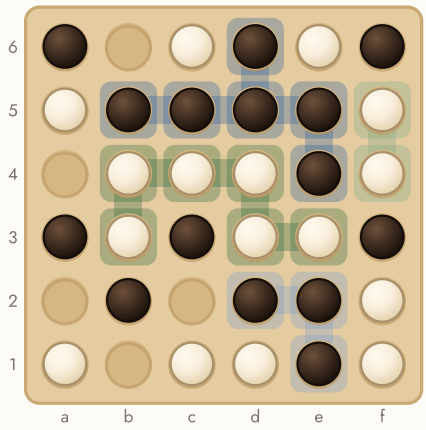
5 The final position. Light's largest group (green) has **7** stones, Dark's (blue) has **5**: **Light wins**.

Playing again?

The loser of the previous game takes Light and plays first.

Names of the squares

Columns a to f, rows 1 to 6; a1 is the doron's home. A game is written as the list of squares the doron is sent to.



6 Another game. Both largest groups have **6** stones. The second groups decide: **3** for Dark against **2** for Light. **Dark wins**.

Club rule (komi)

Between strong players, moving first is a small advantage. To balance it: if both largest groups **and** both second-largest groups are equal, Dark wins.

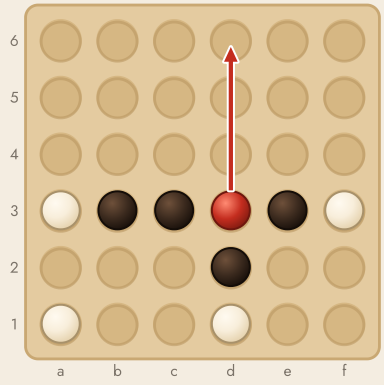
OPTION

Capture

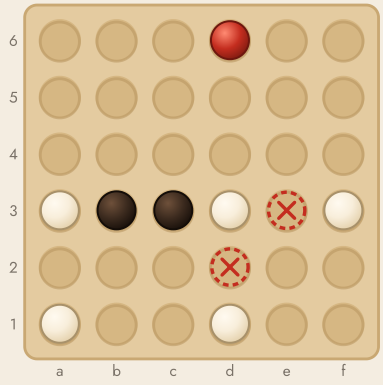
Same game, with one extra rule. After placing your stone, look along the four straight lines from it (up, down, left and right). If **exactly one** opposing stone sits between your new stone and another of your stones, remove it: it goes back to its owner, who can play it again, and the square is empty again, so the doron can pass through it. Each of the four lines is checked: one stone can capture up to four stones at once, one per line.

- Two opposing stones in a row are not captured.
- A capture never triggers another one.
- The doron is neither friend nor foe.
- The last stone, placed where the blocked doron stood, can capture too.
- Very rarely, captures and recaptures repeat the same position. Then stop and count the groups as they stand.

Captures make games livelier (about ten captured stones per game) and draws almost disappear.



7 Light sends the doron from d3 to d6 and places a stone on d3.



8 d2 (between d3 and d1) and e3 (between d3 and f3) are both removed. b3 and c3 are two in a row: they stay.